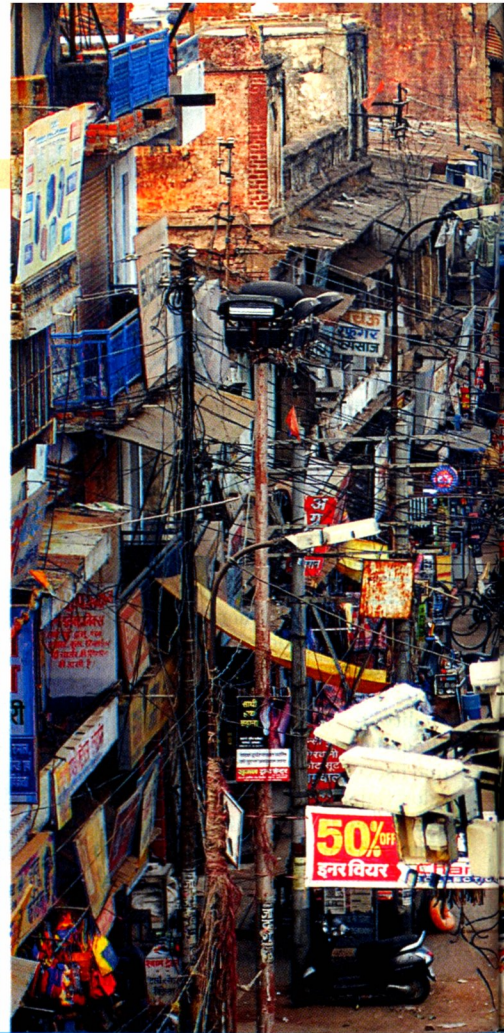


Wasting AWAY

Once an example of a multi-layered past in culture and politics, Allahabad is decaying by the day

Photographs by MANEESH AGNIHOTRI/www.indiatodayimages.com

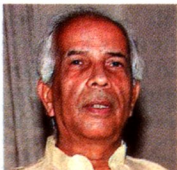


ALLAHABAD HAD "LIBERATED" ITSELF DURING THE GREAT MUTINY OF 1857 BUT

By Subhash Mishra

**“An era
has come
when Allahabad
has lost its
participation in
the national
politics.”**

KESHARI NATH TRIPATHI,
Senior BJP Leader



Seen from the banks of the Yamuna, it looms large over Allahabad, like the citadel of its guardian angel. An architectural icon of one of the city's golden periods, the Allahabad Fort, built by Emperor Akbar and long occupied by his army, was once a barrier between any invader and the city. But no longer, for the impassable sentinel of the Mughal period is falling apart brick by brick, epitomising the continuing decay of the city.

"I have no words to express my sorrow over the dangerous decay of Allahabad as a holy city. If tourists and pilgrims dare to go to the Sangam or the river banks, most of them would lament their visit," regrets Shyam Murthy Badawan, a resident of Johnstonganj—an old locality of Allahabad.

From being the oldest and holiest of Hindu cities to its present state of unchecked deteri-

oration, Allahabad has seen it all. Once known as Prayag, the site of the confluence of three holy rivers—the Ganga, Yamuna and Saraswati—till Mughal rule, it was renamed Allahabad only to be later anglicised to Allahabad. The city's diverse past—it represents the confluence of Hindu, Mughal and British cultures—and the active role it played during the freedom movement stand out in painful contrast to the cultureless population centre it seems have become now. Despite its current state such is the status of the city in the Hindu mythology that an average of 3,000 tourists come here every month.

Barring the periodical hosting of the teeming Kumbh and Magh melas, the waning religious fervour of the erstwhile Prayag is leading the downslide. The banks of the holy Ganga and Yamuna play host to a growing infestation of religious scamsters and assorted holy men even as the rivers suffer the daily addition of 160 million litres of sewage water